CHAPTER THIRTEEN

TATA CHEMICALS

Propelling Change

Incorporated in 1939, Tata Chemicals Limited was mainly in the business of manufacturing industrial chemicals, nutritional and agricultural solutions. Since its inception, it has had a dominant presence in India. It also owns Asia's largest saltworks. Beginning in the 1990s, it made some major foreign acquisitions as well.

In February 2020, its 'consumer products business' was merged with 'Tata Global Beverages Limited'. Today, it is the world's third-largest soda-ash producer and the sixth-largest bicarbonate manufacturer and has 'marketing presence in 30 countries'. The company has thirteen manufacturing plants across the globe and more than 4,600 employees across four continents.

The first major growth phase took place under Darbari Seth. He had launched iodized salt in India for the first time in 1983. Tata Salt has now become a household name in the country where 'eight out of 10 people in the country think of Tata Salt as the first brand when it comes to salt'. It has a market share of more than 25 per cent in India.

By 1992, Tata Chemicals had become a crucial supplier of basic chemicals to the Indian industries. It had also expanded its production of soda ash, considered to be the preserve of the more advanced Western nations. It had made great strides in the production of refined sodium bicarbonate, pure salt and bromides. Seth's name had become synonymous with that of Tata Chemicals.

While he had many successes, Seth had some glaring failures too. The botched Karnal project was one; another was the company's unsuccessful engagement in the Haldia refinery project. He also failed to run Tata